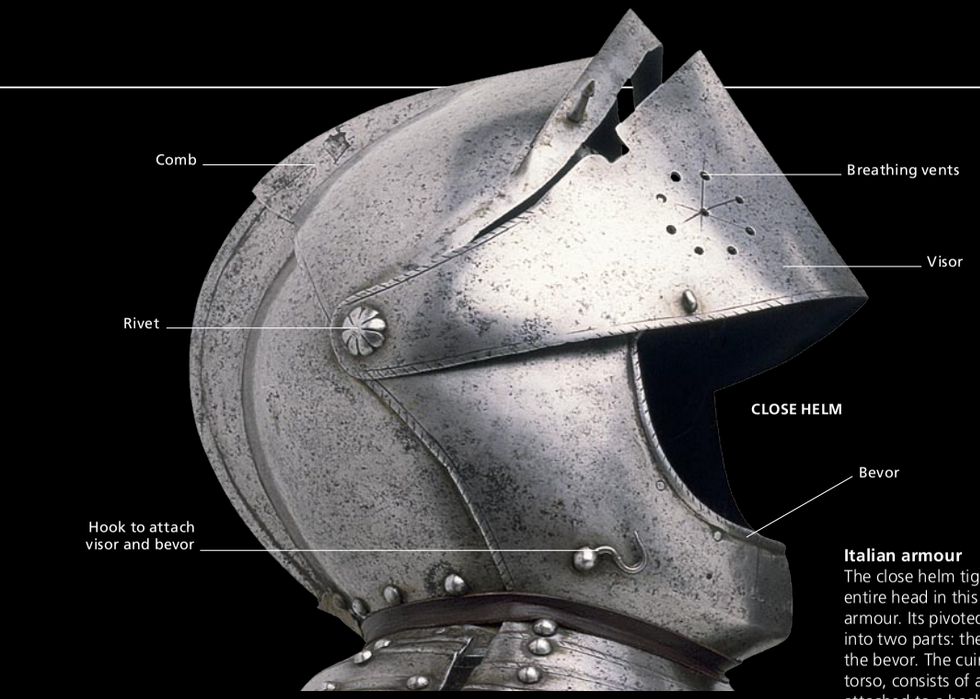
KNIGHT'S ARMS

Full plate armour came into use in the 15th century. While heavy and time-consuming to put on, a well-made suit distributed the weight evenly around the body, allowing reasonable mobility. The wearing of surcoats lapsed so owners could show off their expensive armour. The helmet was curved to deflect blows and had a moveable visor for better airflow. Plate armour gave such good protection against swords that percussive weapons such as hammers and maces grew in popularity.



Italian armour
The close helm tightly encloses the entire head in this 16th-century armour. Its pivoted visor is divided into two parts: the visor proper and the bevor. The cuirass, covering the torso, consists of a breastplate attached to a backplate (not shown) by leather straps. Extending from the breastplate are skirts and tassets to guard the abdomen and upper thighs. Neck, arm, and leg defences complete the head-to-toe protection.





War-hammer
When swung from horseback the war-hammer could cause considerable damage to armour without penetrating it. The spiked head could punch through steel.

Mace
The flanged mace was devised to have a powerful impact on even thick armour and could be wielded from horseback. This steel 16th-century example has seven ornate flanges.